

Lesson 01:

Introduction & Historical Arguments

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Books are traditionally organized chronologically with plots building one on top of another. However, the Quran is unlike any other book. Its sequence is not determined by length, subject or order of revelation, it is determined by divine design.

There are **four major arguments** for the divine ordering of the Quran (in order of increasing strength):

- 1) Historical
- 2) Textual (Ayat talking about the subject of the ordering of the Quran)
- 3) Spiritual
- 4) Case Studies (Studies of how the Quran is organized show that the ordering is too sophisticated, evolved and precise to be an accident or the work of a humanly.)

Example in literature:

“Structure and Quranic Interpretation of the Quran,” a book by Raymond Farrin.

Farrin is specialized in the study of classical Arabic poetry and the analysis of how orally compiled poetry was organized.

Historical Arguments

Argument #1:

Different companions (only a few due to the fact that only a minority were capable of writing) had their own personal written copies of the Quran with surahs appearing in different orders.

- The mushaf of Ubay Ibn Ka'ab was ordered with surah numbers 1,2,3,4,6,...
- Ibn Masood's mushaf was ordered with surah numbers 2,4,3 – Al-Fatihah, Al-Falaq, and An-Nas were not included
- The mushaf of Ali ibn Abi Talib was ordered according to the chronology of revelation starting with surah numbers 96, 74, 50, 11, 81, etc..

Opinions:

As a consequence of this, some argue that the Quran is ordered according to the consensus reached by the companions.

- Counter argument: The sayings of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) himself as well as the allusion to the idea of heavenly sequence.

Argument #2:

Another argument is that only some surahs are in divine order but not all due to certain hadiths in which Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) specifically talked about their order.

Examples of ordering of some surahs:

- The 7 first long surahs (2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, and 8) were recited by the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) in this order
- Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) recited the protective surahs 17, 18, 19, 20, and 21 in this order, just as they are ordered in the Quran
- Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) recited the last 3 surahs of the Quran before going to sleep in their preserved order

Argument #3:

The third historical argument says that Caliph Uthman ibn Affan (RA), in his copy of the Quran, put Surah At-Tawba and Surah Al-Anfal together as one Surah.

- Ibn Azhar reports that Abu Muhammad said that Uthman (RA) commanded them that they should follow the 7 long surahs (السَّبع الطَّوَال).
- The long surahs are Surah Al-Baqara, Ali 'Imran, An-Nisa, Al-Ma'ida, Al-An'am, Al-A'raf, and Al-Anfal. (Surah Al-Fatiha is not included)
- But Uthman (RA) said to include Surah At-Tawba as the seventh long surah, basically joining Surah Anfal and Tawba together as one Surah.
- He said that because there's no gap between the surahs, there's no "Bismillah" between the two Surahs.
- Ibn Abbas went and asked Uthman (RA) why he combined Surah Al-Anfal, which is from the first group of seven (مَنَافِي), with Surah At-Tawba which is from the group of مِثْنِينَ (surahs that have over a hundred ayahs)
- Uthman (RA) said that Surah Al-Anfal was one of the earliest surahs to be revealed in Madinah as it deals with the Battle of Badr. And Surah Tawba was one of the last surahs to be revealed in the Quran and it deals with engaging in war.
- So seeing how similar the two surahs were he thought they were one surah, but because the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) was no longer alive, he couldn't ask him.
- "The surahs used to be revealed to the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) at the same time." There were multiple incomplete projects in the heart of the Prophet (PBUH). This was all an editorial process by a man who couldn't read or write.
- Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) never told them if they were two separate surahs or one surah, they just know there's no "bismillah".
- So after coming to this conclusion he decided to put Surah Al-Anfal and Surah At-Tawba as one surah all together.

Some people use this scenario as a counter argument against heavenly order in the Quran, but it's not a counter argument at all because there's nothing about order in the first place. The order would still be 8th and 9th (Surah Al-Anfal and Surah At-Tawba). The only discussion happening is whether they are one surah or not, the discussion wasn't even about heavenly order. The sequence (whether you put "bismillah" or not) would be the same anyway.

Historical Arguments in Favor of Heavenly Order

Description: In this section Ustadh Nouman goes over arguments in favor of the Quran being in heavenly order.

Sentiments:

- Angel Jibreel said: "This (The order which he recited to the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is the order in which the Quran is in the heavens and, whoever tries to put a later surah earlier or an earlier surah later and say that that's how it is and it doesn't make a difference, has corrupted the organization of the Quran."
- Rabi'a (RA) was asked "How come Al-Baqara was placed before Ali 'Imran when some 80 surahs were already revealed in Mecca. Why is Al-Baqara at the beginning? I get why Al-Fatihah is at the beginning but why Al-Baqara?" Basically asking why the surahs weren't in chronological order.
- Rabi'a (RA) replied: "They were placed earlier and the Quran was authored in this way in accordance with the knowledge of its author. And this is something that is not up for discussion."
- Imam Hamiduddin Farahi said: "As far as the Quran being exactly as it was meant to be from the time of the Prophet (PBUH), this is an issue no one can doubt except someone who is ignorant of history. All of the surahs in this order used to be recited in the prayer, at the time of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) and that is coming to us from both of the chain of narrations. And whenever someone has an issue with the order it's always an issue with the order of the surahs, not the order of the ayat. Was that from the time of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) or was it something that later on compilers put together? And the correct view? The established view that the organization of the surahs in the Quran is also from Allah himself. This is what Jibreel brought and this is what he taught Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) and he taught the companions the way he learned it himself"

Argument #1:

- If you believe the order of the Quran, according to Allah, is a different one then look at the sahaba
- These are people who don't do a single thing that they're not sure about, if it has to do with Islam they want to make sure that it's actually from Allah and from Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) and not someone else

- Abu Bakr (RA) would not even write the Quran in a book because the book form was not at the time of the Prophet (PBUH).
- And even though the حُقَاط were being killed at that time and there was a necessity to preserve the Quran, he was still not willing to do it because they were too careful with anything to do with the Quran. They didn't want to accidentally make anything up. It wasn't on paper when the Prophet (PBUH) was alive so how could they put it on paper? That was the level of sensitivity the companions had.
- He argues that the fact that no one raised an issue when the Quran was organized in the way it is now, shows that they all knew that it was divine.
- The people whose copies had different sequences burnt their copies because they knew it was divine and in heavenly order.
- There should have been hundreds of variations of the sequence of the Quran, but the fact that you don't find that in history, the fact that the sahaba aren't debating this shows that it was clear as day since the time of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH).
- The fact that you don't find the sahaba debating this in of itself shows that it's heavenly order. They could have only agreed because it's heavenly order. The fact that debates don't exist in history is proof enough.

Argument #2

- Hadith of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH): Abu Dawud Ath-Thaqifi said: "I was among the delegation that became Muslim that came from the tribe of Banu Thaqif." And when he came to meet Prophet Muhammad (PBUH), the Prophet wouldn't come out of his tent to meet them. When he came out he said "a حِزْب of the Quran dawned on me (overwhelmed me) and so I didn't want to come out until I finished reciting the entire portion."
- Notice he didn't say "Surah of the Quran" he said "حِزْب".
- So because the delegation of Banu Thaqif were new Muslims they didn't understand what the Prophet meant by حِزْب. So they went to the companions and asked them "How do you portion the Quran?"
- They (multiple companions) responded: "We portion the Quran into 7 portions: 1st portion is 3 surahs, 2nd portion is 5 surahs, 3rd is 7 surahs, 4th is 9 surahs, 5th is 11 surahs, 6th is 13 surahs, and 7th is 65 surahs." Add Surah Al-Fatiha and you get 114 surahs in all.
- This is how the sahaba used to finish reading the Quran in one week.

The weakest arguments to use to convince someone of the Quran being in heavenly order are the historical arguments.

Argument #3:

- If the Quran was in the order of the mind of the companions, they would have taken all the Alif Laam Meems and put them together. They would have put all the surahs that have similar looking beginnings and endings together.

- The fact that you don't find apparently logical order itself means that human logic wasn't involved.